

Chinese Qing Dynasty

The last imperial dynasty of China, the Qing, ruled from 1644 to 1912, and created the largest and wealthiest empire in the world. Expanding into Central Asia, Tibet and Siberia, their economic success resulted in increased patronage of the arts, which mixed the Qing's own Manchu traditions and language with older Chinese styles and customs. Qing emperors were generally conservative in their tastes, and early Qing art was dominated by two styles of painting: the Six Masters of the Early Qing, who followed the conventions of Chinese landscape painting, copying past masterpieces with fine, even and distinct marks, and the Four Great Monk Painters, who used landscapes to express contemporary feelings and political views, painting spontaneously with delicate and expressive brushstrokes.

Increased wealth among the merchant class stimulated demand for crafts such as textiles and pottery, often decorated with meticulously painted scenes in bright colours. In the 18th century, exotic statues and artefacts filled newly built Buddhist temples.



Shen Nanpi, *Pair of Phoenixes*, 1735